

ON TECHNIQUE

Castrato singers

The castration of males before puberty to create a high-pitched singing voice in adulthood was practiced in Italy from the 16th century. From about 1680, it became customary for a castrato to sing the lead male role in Italian opera. Some castrati achieved wealth and celebrity status, admired for their purity of sound, breath control, and elaborate ornamentation of melody. The most famous—Senesino (Francesco Bernardi), Caffarelli (Gaetano Majorano), and Farinelli (Carlo Broschi)—all sang in Handel's operas. The tradition died out around 1790, killed off by changing musical taste and humanitarian revulsion at the castration of children.



PORTRAIT OF FARINELLI, CORRADO GIAQUINTO, c. 1753

Georg Friederich Händel was born in the German town of Halle, near Leipzig, in 1685. He later anglicized his name to George Frideric Handel. His father served as barber-surgeon to the local aristocracy and his mother was the daughter of a Lutheran pastor. Prosperous members of the middle class, they intended Georg to